6000 personnel, with a built-up area of around 7.5 lakh square metres, to be constructed in five years. I was keen on getting the site formally approved because I had seen how frequent changes to the site had delayed projects indefinitely. The site had another major advantage that, being in the heart of Delhi Cantt, it would save considerable time in commuting. In fact, most personnel would be even able to walk or cycle to the office, thereby also contributing to a green environment.

We had decided right at the outset that the TSB should be an iconic building, something that we could be proud of. Since it would be visible from the air as aircraft came in to land at the IGI Airport, it needed to be pleasing to look at, yet functionally efficient. For this, we decided to call in experts from outside to design the building. We gave the designers our vision of the building, and they came up with a most contemporary and apt design. The design envisaged two wings to be connected with a circular bridge area, topped by an Ashoka Chakra, depicting the crossed swords and shield which is the Army insignia. Once the concept was approved, it was now time to get on with the actual design of the building, the floor plan and specifications, and most importantly, the amenities. In doing so, we also had to rein in our ambitions to remain within the budget. An idea to have a rooftop helipad, for example, had to be shelved. The plans and proposals kept going up and down the various departments of the MoD and were in the final stages of approval when I retired.

Gen Manoj Pande, in turn, further carried forward the project, which was finally approved in early 2023, for an amount of Rs 760 crore, to be completed by 2025. I am sanguine that once completed, it will be something we will all be proud of. Continuity and Change go hand in hand.

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